



JOINING THE FRAY: AIADMK's Jayalalithaa has her own schemes to rival DMK's

counter the anti-incumbency mood that has set in due to inflation, fuel scarcity and price rise. The reaction of the Opposition was on expected lines. DMK's Vijayakanth described the offer as a pre-election gimmick and said in the next elections the state Government might stoop to offer rice completely free of cost to garner votes. The AIADMK too was quick to criticise the Government's move as short sighted. "What will people do with rice? They need rasam, sambar, curry

to eat," thundered Jayalalithaa in a party meeting. The next day, Karunanidhi coupled his offer of Re 1 per kilo rice with 10 cooking ingredients, the same ones that Jayalalithaa was talking about.

Populism in Tamil Nadu has become a game of one-upmanship under the present Karunanidhi Government. Even though the Opposition parties continue to tease the Government, it remains unmoved on this score. The ever-burgeoning sops have burdened

the exchequer with Rs 14,114 crore by 2007-08 and the figure is expected to shoot up to around Rs17,104 crore by 2010. The Re 1 per kilo scheme itself is expected to double the burden of Rs 1,950 crore annually for the exchequer due to the existing Rs 2 per kilo rice scheme. "Instead of freebies and sops, the Government should focus on education, health and transport. When the basic facilities would remain out of reach for the common man, the sops can't augur well for the all-round development of the state," says former Planning Commission member and retired IAS officer A.K. Venkata Subramanian.

Vaiko's MDMK too organised a grand conference at Madurai to commemorate the Anna centenary. Party sources claim that it was a show of strength with over 40,000 supporters turning up at the meet. But for Vaiko, it was yet another occasion to lay claim on the legacy of Anna. "We are the real DMK that stands by the ideals of Anna," said Vaiko. Predicting a split in the DMK, he hopes that it would drive them towards the MDMK and his leadership.

Much water has flown down the Cooum river ever since the first non-Congress government headed by Annadurai came to power in Madras in 1967. Dravidian parties that split and multiplied have taken turns at power, enticing voters each time with innovative sops. The only constant has been the Congress, which went out of power 41 years ago and since remained out. ■

ANNA ON THEIR MINDS			
	DMK	AIADMK	MDMK
	It has introduced rice at Re 1 per kg at the PDS shops and 10 cooking ingredients at a subsidised price of Rs 50. It would also upgrade primary health centres while providing free nutritious food to pregnant women.	It would organise training sessions in tailoring, computer skills and driving for members of the youth and women division of the party, apart from holding public meetings and poetry competitions at all party units.	It organised a grand regional conference reportedly attended by nearly its 40,000 supporters to commemorate Anna's birth centenary, along with a photo exhibition with his rare pictures and a debate on his contributions.